

DWP Future Employment Support Factsheet

Overview

The Future Employment Support (FES) programme is the Department for Work and Pensions' next-generation contracted employment support service, intended to replace the current Restart Scheme when it concludes. Scheduled to launch in February 2028, the programme will provide employment support across England through contracts worth approximately £1.2 billion over an initial three-year referral period, with options to extend for up to a further two years.

FES forms a key part of the Government's wider Get Britain Working agenda and is designed to support unemployed Universal Credit claimants into sustainable employment through personalised, locally tailored interventions. Unlike previous national employment programmes, FES is being co-designed with Mayoral Strategic Authorities and local partners, reflecting a significant shift towards place-based commissioning and greater integration between employment, skills, health and local economic priorities.

Purpose and Target Groups

The programme aims to reduce long-term unemployment, increase sustained employment and earnings, and support individuals facing multiple barriers to work. It will serve several participant groups, including:

- Long-term unemployed Universal Credit claimants, with mandatory referral after 12 months.
- Young people, with mandatory referral after 6 months.
- Lone parents and lead carers, with voluntary access from day one.
- Other disadvantaged groups, with voluntary access from day one.

Work Coaches will retain discretion over suitability, ensuring referrals are appropriate and aligned with participants' circumstances and existing support arrangements.

Support Offer

FES will provide a structured 12-month support journey centred on personalised, one-to-one engagement, delivered in person wherever possible. Support will begin with a comprehensive diagnostic assessment and continue through action planning, regular reviews and employment progression activities.

The service is expected to include:

- Personalised employment support based on individual barriers and aspirations
- Skills development, accredited training and work experience opportunities.
- Job matching, employer engagement, job fairs and job brokering.
- Intensive support with CV development, applications and interview preparation.
- Self-employment guidance and enterprise support where appropriate.
- Assistance to help participants manage health conditions in work.
- Specialist interventions such as ESOL provision, addiction support and neurodiversity services.
- Practical support including travel costs, childcare, replacement care and other participation-related expenses.

A distinctive feature of the programme is its emphasis on supporting participants with health-related barriers. Ministers have indicated that many participants are expected to have health conditions, and suppliers will be expected to deliver non-clinical interventions that help individuals prepare for, enter and sustain work.

Local Tailoring and Integration

One of the most significant changes from previous programmes is the emphasis on local design and delivery.

Suppliers will be required to work closely with Mayoral Strategic Authorities, local authorities, Jobcentre Plus, the emerging Jobs and Careers Service, employers and local service providers. They will be expected to develop and maintain local engagement plans, build strategic partnerships and ensure that support reflects local labour market conditions and economic priorities.

This approach aligns with the Government's devolution agenda and reflects a growing recognition that employment outcomes are improved when services are integrated with local health, skills, housing and community support systems.

What Makes FES Different?

Compared with Restart and earlier national programmes, Future Employment Support is expected to place greater emphasis on:

- Local flexibility rather than standardised national delivery models.
- Personalised journeys tailored to individual needs and barriers.
- Integration of employment, health and skills services.

- Work experience, job trials and employer engagement.
- Support for individuals facing complex and multiple disadvantages.
- Collaboration with local government and devolved institutions.
- Long-term employment sustainability rather than rapid job entry alone.

Performance and Outcomes

The proposed performance framework focuses on sustained employment outcomes rather than short-term job starts.

The current proposed job outcome measure is the percentage of participants who, within 547 days of programme start, achieve earnings equivalent to at least 18 hours per week at National Living Wage for 26 weeks. This may be achieved through paid employment or through self-employment activity equivalent to six months of work.

This approach reflects the programme's focus on sustainable employment, progression and longer-term economic participation.

Procurement and Commercial Approach

The programme will be procured using the Competitive Flexible Procedure under the Procurement Act 2023 and will follow a three-stage process:

1. Participation Stage (Procurement Specific Questionnaire and technical assessment).
2. Commercial Dialogue.
3. Best and Final Offer (BAFO).

DWP currently anticipates awarding one contract per Contract Package Area (CPA), with procurement activity commencing in late 2026 and contract awards expected during 2027 ahead of mobilisation for the February 2028 launch.

Supply Chain and Partnership Expectations

Future Employment Support places considerable emphasis on partnership working and supply chain diversity.

DWP has indicated that successful bidders will be expected to operate supply chains and ensure that at least 25% of supply chain expenditure within each CPA is delivered through Small and Medium Enterprises (SMEs). The Department has also

set an aspirational objective of achieving 40% SME and VCSE participation across supply chains over the life of the programme.

This signals a strong intention to create opportunities for specialist local providers, voluntary organisations and community-based delivery partners while maintaining accountability through prime contractor arrangements.

Strategic Implications

Future Employment Support represents one of the most significant employability commissioning opportunities expected over the next two years. The programme signals a clear move away from centrally prescribed employment services towards locally integrated, partnership-based delivery.

Organisations seeking to participate are likely to require:

- Strong relationships with Combined Authorities, Mayoral Strategic Authorities and local government.
- Demonstrable employer engagement capability.
- Experience integrating employment, skills and health support.
- Robust local partnership and referral networks.
- The ability to deliver personalised support to participants with complex barriers.
- Evidence of achieving sustained employment outcomes and delivering value for money.

Overall, Future Employment Support represents a fundamental evolution in employment support policy, combining personalised interventions, local commissioning, health integration and stronger collaboration across public, private and voluntary sectors to help more people move into sustainable work and contribute to economic growth.